MODULE 34 · DOMAIN 3 - BUSINESS ENVIRONMENT

Change control across approaches

The change control process, who decides, change in agile and hybrid work, communicating decisions, implementing approved changes, and keeping records straight.

DOMAIN III - Business Environment EXAM WEIGHT 26% MODULE 34 of 49

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Change is welcome. Uncontrolled change is not.

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The change control process

01

Request

The change is written down and logged.

02

Analyse

Impact on scope, schedule, cost, quality, risk, resources.

03

Decide

The right authority approves, rejects or defers.

04

Communicate

Requester and those affected are told why.

05

Implement and update

Do it, verify it, update baselines and documents.

ON THE EXAM

Analysis comes before the decision, and before anyone does the work. That order is the exam's favourite test.

The first thing to do with a change request

- **Analyse the impact**, with the team, before anything else.
- Not: implement it because the requester is important.
- Not: reject it because it was not in the plan.
- Not: send it straight to the sponsor without analysis.
- Then submit it, with the analysis and options, to whoever has the authority to decide.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> 'A stakeholder asks for a change. What should the PM do first?' Almost always: assess the impact.

Kinds of change request

TYPE	PURPOSE
Corrective action	Bring performance back in line with the plan
Preventive action	Stop a future deviation from the plan
Defect repair	Fix a product that does not meet requirements
Update or enhancement	Change scope, requirements, plans or baselines

ON THE EXAM

All four go through change control when they affect baselines. Small corrective actions may sit within the PM's tolerance.

Who decides

- Governance sets the **authority levels**: the tolerance table from module 31.
- A **change control board** decides changes beyond the project manager's authority.
- The project manager facilitates: analyses, recommends, and records the decision.
- Approving a change above your tolerance, however sensible, is acting beyond authority.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> The PM runs the process and recommends. The decision belongs to whoever governance names.

Predictive or adaptive change?

PREDICTIVE

Formal change control

- Scope is baselined early
- Changes go through a change request
- Board or sponsor decides
- Baselines updated after approval

ADAPTIVE

The backlog absorbs change

- Scope is expected to evolve
- New items go into the product backlog
- The product owner orders them
- Time and cost stay fixed; scope flexes

THE TIEBREAKER

In agile work, the backlog is the change mechanism for product scope. No change request is needed for that.

Change on hybrid projects

- Inside a release boundary, the **product owner** reorders the backlog freely.
- Changes that affect a **milestone, budget, contract or governance baseline** go through formal change control.
- Agree the boundary at the start: what the product owner may decide, and what needs the board.
- Formal change requests for every story, or no control at all over budgets, are both wrong.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> On hybrid work, ask: does this change stay inside the agreed boundary? Inside: backlog. Outside: change control.

Keeping the records straight

RECORD	WHAT IT HOLDS
Change log	Every request: description, requester, date, analysis, decision, status
Configuration management	Which version of each deliverable and document is current
Version control	History of changes to code, designs and documents
Baselines	The approved scope, schedule and cost, as updated by approved changes

ON THE EXAM

Change control decides; configuration management keeps track of what exists. Both are needed.

Communicating the status of changes

- The outline asks you to **communicate the status of proposed changes**.
- Tell the requester the decision **and the reason**, promptly, whatever it is.
- Tell everyone affected: the team, suppliers, stakeholders whose work changes.
- Keep the change log visible, so status is easy to find.
- A rejected change nobody explained comes back, often as a request to a team member directly.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Every decision, approve, reject or defer, is communicated with its reason.

Implementing approved changes

- The outline asks you to **implement approved changes to the project**.
- Plan the work, assign it, and schedule it like any other work.
- Verify and test the change; check nothing else broke.
- Only approved changes are implemented. Work started early is unauthorised, even if later approved.
- Genuine emergencies follow an agreed **emergency change** route, recorded and reviewed afterwards.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Approval first, then implementation. Emergency changes still get recorded and reviewed.

Updating documentation

- The outline's fourth change enabler: **update project documentation** to reflect changes.
- Baselines: scope, schedule, cost.
- Plans and registers: risk register, requirements traceability, stakeholder register.
- Contracts: amended through their formal change clauses.
- An approved change that never reaches the documents leaves the team working from the old version.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> A change is not finished until every affected document and baseline reflects it.

When there are too many changes

- A flood of change requests is a **symptom**, not just a workload.
- Look for the root cause: unclear requirements, missing stakeholders, or the wrong approach.
- Fix the cause: better elicitation, engaging the missing stakeholder, or moving that work to an adaptive approach.
- Freezing all change stops learning. Processing changes faster treats the symptom.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Many changes in one area: find out why. Module 03's reporting workstream is the classic case.

Project Lantern: change control

- **App**: the product owner reorders the backlog freely within each release.
- **Boundary**: anything moving a clinic go-live, the budget or the kiosk contract goes to the change board.
- **Change log** visible to all; every decision emailed to the requester with the reason.
- When the regulator added a new consent screen, it was analysed, approved by the board, then built and documented.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> A backlog for product change, a board for baseline change, and a visible log for both.

Scenario signals and the move

THE SCENARIO SAYS	THE MOVE
A stakeholder requests a change; what first?	Analyse the impact
The board has approved a change	Implement, verify, update baselines and documents, communicate
A change was made without approval	Assess it, take it through change control, coach the team
New story on an agile team, within budget and time	Product owner adds and orders it; no change request
A rejected requester keeps asking	Communicate the decision and the reason
A flood of change requests	Find the root cause

ON THE EXAM

Analyse, decide at the right level, communicate, implement, update. And ask why when changes pile up.

> On a predictive project to build a warehouse management system, the head of logistics asks the project manager to add a barcode-scanning feature that was not in the scope baseline.
>
> She says it is important and should be easy.

What should the project manager do first?

A Ask the team to add the feature, since the head of logistics is a key stakeholder.

B Analyse the impact of the change on scope, schedule, cost and risk with the team.

C Reject the request, since it is not in the scope baseline.

D Send the request straight to the sponsor for a decision.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager do first?

A Just add it.

Uncontrolled change. 'Should be easy' is an assumption, not an analysis.

B Analyse the impact first.

The first step of change control, before any decision.

C Reject it.

Refuses a possibly valuable change without assessing it.

D Straight to the sponsor.

A decision-maker needs the analysis first; it may even be within the PM's tolerance.

THE SIGNAL

A change request, and the question says 'first': analyse the impact.

> The change control board has approved a change to add a second data centre for resilience, with an increase to budget and a four-week extension.
>
> The project manager receives the approval.

What should the project manager do next?

A Close the change request in the change log.

B Re-analyse the change to confirm the board's decision.

C Implement the change, update the baselines and project documents, and communicate the decision.

D Ask the sponsor to sign the change as well.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager do next?

A Close the request.

Premature. Nothing has been implemented or updated yet.

B Re-analyse.

The analysis was done before the decision. Repeating it adds delay.

C Implement, update, communicate.

The outline's enablers after approval: implement, update documents, communicate status.

D Get the sponsor to sign too.

The board had the authority. An extra signature is unnecessary.

THE SIGNAL

After approval: implement, update baselines and documents, and tell everyone affected.

> During a review, the project manager finds that a developer changed a report layout at a customer's direct request. The change was not submitted or approved.
>
> The customer is pleased, but the change affects two other reports that depend on the layout.

What should the project manager do?

A Remove the change immediately and restore the original layout.

B Leave the change in place, since the customer is pleased.

C Formally reprimand the developer.

D Assess the impact, take the change through change control, and coach the team on the process.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager do?

A Remove it at once.

Reacts without analysis, and frustrates a pleased customer.

B Leave it.

Ignores the impact on two dependent reports, and rewards bypassing the process.

C Reprimand the developer.

Blame. Coaching fixes the behaviour; the change still needs deciding.

D Assess, take through control, coach.

Brings the change under control and prevents the next one.

THE SIGNAL

An unapproved change found: assess it, put it through the process now, and coach so it does not recur.

> On an agile product team, the product owner wants to add a new user story to the backlog after feedback at a sprint review. It fits within the release's agreed budget and date.
>
> It does not affect any contract or milestone.

How should the change be handled?

A The product owner adds the story to the backlog and orders it against other items.

B Submit a formal change request to the change control board.

C Refuse the story until the next release is planned.

D Ask the sponsor to approve the new story.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

How should the change be handled?

A The PO adds and orders it.

Inside the agreed boundary, the backlog is the change mechanism.

B Formal change request.

Predictive machinery for a change that stays inside the release boundary.

C Refuse until next release.

Rejects exactly the feedback-driven change agile is designed for.

D Sponsor approval.

Product priorities within the release belong to the product owner.

THE SIGNAL

Agile, inside budget and date, no contract impact: the product owner uses the backlog. No change request.

> Three weeks ago, the change control board rejected a request from the marketing manager. Nobody told her the decision.
>
> She has since asked two developers directly when her change will be ready.

What should the project manager do?

A Ignore it; the developers can tell her it was rejected.

B Tell the marketing manager the decision and the reasons, and make sure the change log shows its status.

C Ask the developers to implement it quietly to keep her happy.

D Resubmit the change to the board on her behalf.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager do?

A Leave it to the developers.

Pushes a governance message onto the team, without the reasons.

B Communicate the decision and reasons; update the log.

The outline's enabler: communicate the status of proposed changes.

C Implement it quietly.

Overrides the board. Unauthorised change.

D Resubmit it for her.

Nothing new has been offered. She has not even heard the decision.

THE SIGNAL

An unexplained decision comes back through side channels. Communicate every decision, with its reason.

> In one month, a predictive project has received forty change requests. Most are clarifications of reporting requirements from the finance department, which was consulted only briefly during planning.
>
> The change control board is overwhelmed.

What should the project manager do?

A Process the requests faster by holding extra board meetings.

B Freeze all changes until the project is complete.

C Address the root cause: engage finance properly to clarify its reporting requirements, and consider an adaptive approach for that area.

D Hire more business analysts to write the change requests.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager do?

A More board meetings.
Treats the symptom; the flood continues.

B Freeze all change.
Stops learning; finance gets reports it cannot use.

C Fix the cause: engage finance; consider adaptive.
Finds why the changes happen, and stops the flood at its source.

D More analysts.
Writes the change requests faster. The cause remains.

THE SIGNAL

A flood of changes from one group: a missed stakeholder or the wrong approach. Fix the cause.

Analyse, decide at the right level, communicate, implement, update.

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